Who Can Answer What

Fifteen questions about Mom's money and her care bills, sorted by who to ask, with room to write what they say.

Some of what you need is in Mom's paperwork. The rest is held by somebody: the bank, the insurance company, the billing office, a brother or sister. Bring the questions written down, ask them as they are, and write the answer under each one.

This guide doesn't answer the questions and doesn't say which matters most. That depends on Mom's situation and on where she lives, and the people below are the ones who can speak to it.

Mom, and the family

Mom herself, if she is able and willing to talk about it. Then brothers, sisters and anyone who has helped with her bills or her taxes.

1. Which banks, accounts, pensions or insurance policies do you know of, including any from years ago?

2. Where are the statements, policies, tax returns and property papers kept?

3. As far as you know, is anyone's name besides Mom's on an account, a policy or a piece of property?

The bank or credit union

Any bank or credit union where Mom has, or had, an account.

1. What do you need from us before you can talk with us about Mom's accounts?

2. Which accounts does Mom have here, and how can we get recent statements for each one?

3. Whose names are on each account, and exactly how is each one titled?

Whoever pays her monthly income

Social Security, a pension office, an annuity company. One call for each.

1. What is Mom's monthly payment, what is taken out of it, and can we have that in writing?

The insurance company

For life insurance, an annuity or a long-term care policy. Have the policy or contract in front of you when you call.

1. For a life insurance policy or an annuity: who owns it, who is named on it, and what is its current cash value? Can we have that in writing?

2. For a long-term care policy: is the care Mom is getting now covered, and how do we start a claim?

The facility's business office or the care provider

Whoever sends the bill for Mom's care.

1. What is the monthly charge for Mom's care, what does it include, and what is billed separately?

2. Which charges on this bill come every month, and which were one-time?

Your Medicaid planner

The person who looks at the whole financial picture: income, assets, expenses, insurance and current care costs, who owns what, and what is still missing.

1. How much of what Mom has is actually available to pay for her care?

2. Which financial records do you need from us right now, and how far back should they go?

3. How long can Mom afford to keep paying privately, and what goes into working that out?

4. We came across some withdrawals, gifts or transfers we'd like to ask about. What do you need to know about each one?

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't answer these questions, put them in order of importance, or say what any answer means for paying for Mom's care. Rules vary by state, and nothing here is legal, financial or tax advice. Questions about Medicaid, the law or taxes go to your Medicaid planner or the appropriate licensed professional.

Ready for the next step?

You have your questions, and you know who each one goes to. As the answers come in, the planning interview gives them somewhere to go: it asks about your family's situation and gives you a free planning report you can bring to your Medicaid planner or to any conversation about paying for care.

Get Your Free Planning Report ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

The first question for Mom and the family follows questions AARP suggests asking about a loved one's accounts. The question about a long-term care policy follows Medicare's suggestion to check the policy or call the insurance company. The grouping by role is ours.

1. AARP, 5 Steps to Organize Your Loved One's Financial Records
2. Medicare.gov (Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services), How can I pay for nursing home care?